

Day 3 — Communicating Technical Trade-Offs to Non-Technical Partners

Activity packet for participant triads. Today's job: take **one trade-off** from your TCD Section 5 or TMD, translate it for a non-technical executive, and produce a 1-page brief that wins (or honestly loses) the call.

Where we are in the week

The TCD Section 5 has top-5 trade-offs documented. Each is named in technical terms — the right framing for an architect or eng lead. Today we **translate one** into a brief that lands with a CFO, a Customer Success lead, or an executive sponsor.

By 16:00, every triad has SEP Section 3 — a one-page trade-off brief.

Inputs

- TCD Section 5 (top-5 trade-offs)
- TMD Section 1–Section 5 (data, cloud, API, sequence, baselines — sources of additional trade-offs)
- SEP Section 1–Section 2 (stakeholder map and engagement plan — informs *which* stakeholder)

The translation discipline (today's mental model)

Translating technical to business is not "use simpler words." It's **re-framing**: same trade-off, expressed in terms the audience already cares about.

Technical framing	Business framing
"We chose async write to audit because sync would breach our p95 SLO"	"We chose to ship 50ms faster on the dispatcher screen, accepting that audit logs may lag 10 seconds — important for compliance Q3 review timing"
"We accepted denormalized ticket_ids array in ReconcileEvent"	"We're optimizing reconcile reads at the cost of a future query type. We'd revisit if that query becomes hot"
"We're ship a modular monolith, not a service"	"We're shipping faster by not separating this code; we accept the cost of a future split if traffic grows 5x"

A non-technical exec doesn't need the technical framing. They need:

- **What's at stake** (in their currency: cost, customer outcome, regulatory exposure, time)
- **What we're choosing** (in plain language)
- **What we're *not* choosing**, and why
- **What we'd need to change our mind**
- **What we're asking from them** (decision / approval / information)

The "what they need to know vs what they need to decide" frame

A common rookie mistake: a brief tries to teach the executive everything. They don't have time, and they shouldn't need it.

What they need to know	What they need to decide
The headline outcome	Whether to approve the choice
The cost we're accepting	Whether the cost is acceptable
The trigger to revisit	Whether the trigger is well-chosen
What we need from them	Whether to provide it

Strip everything else. Detail goes in the appendix or "available on request."

The 1-page brief template

```
# Trade-off brief: <short feature name>
**For:** <stakeholder name> | **From:** <triad> | **Date:** <today>

## The decision (1 sentence)
We are choosing [X] over [Y] for the <feature> work, accepting [cost].

## Why this matters to you (1–2 sentences in their currency)
<Cost / customer outcome / regulatory exposure / time>

## The choice
- **What we're doing:** <plain language; 2–3 bullets>
- **What we're explicitly not doing:** <2–3 bullets>
- **The cost we're accepting:** <1 bullet>

## What would change our mind
<Concrete trigger; metric or organizational change>

## What we need from you
☐ Approval to proceed as proposed
☐ Specific concern you want us to address
☐ Information we don't have

## Appendix (linked, not pasted)
- Technical detail in TCD Section 5 / TMD SectionX
- Sequence diagram
- SLO budget
```

The discipline: the **whole brief** fits on one page. The appendix is references, not body.

Activity 1 — Translation Drill

Format: Triad • 35 min • Block 1

Purpose

Calibrate the translation muscle on examples before applying it to the triad's own trade-off.

The translation pack — 6 technical statements

For each, the triad writes the business-framing version targeting a specific stakeholder.

#	Technical statement	Stakeholder	Their currency
1	"We're using read replicas which will introduce up to 3-second consistency lag"	Customer Success	Customer impact
2	"p99 latency budget can't fit our happy path; we propose relaxing to p95"	Eng Director	Engineering velocity
3	"We need an additional region to satisfy data residency for 8% of customers"	CFO	Cost
4	"Token-based auth requires a new SSO scope"	Identity team lead	Operational risk
5	"We're deferring tablet support to v2"	Sales lead	Revenue / deal velocity
6	"Audit-log retention requires 24 months of cold storage"	Compliance lead	Regulatory exposure

Triad protocol

1. **Pick 3 of the 6** (5 min). Mix of stakeholders.
2. **Translate each** (20 min) using the audience's currency.
3. **Critique the translations** (10 min). For each: would the stakeholder act on this brief? Would they have follow-up questions? What's missing?

Readout (60 sec per triad)

"The translation we're proudest of was [#X] for [stakeholder]. The hardest one was [#Y] because [why]."

Activity 2 — Pick Your Trade-Off + Pick Your Stakeholder

Format: Triad • 40 min • Block 2

Purpose

Pick one of your TCD Section 5 trade-offs (or a TMD trade-off) AND one stakeholder, then design the brief together.

Triad protocol

1. **Review your top-5 trade-offs** (5 min). Pull from TCD Section 5 + any from TMD Sections 1–4.
2. **Pick the trade-off** (10 min). Criteria:

- It's **decision-shaped** — there's a real call to make
 - The stakeholder you'd brief has **power to approve or block**
 - Trade-off has a **non-obvious cost** that needs explaining
3. **Pick the stakeholder** (10 min). Pull from SEP Section 1. Ideally a **high-power** stakeholder (HI or LI quadrant).
 4. **Predict 5 questions they'll ask** (15 min). Their first 5 questions; rank by likelihood.

What "good" looks like

- The trade-off has a **real call** the stakeholder can make
- The stakeholder is in the **right quadrant** for this kind of decision
- The 5 predicted questions include **at least one hostile** one

Worked example — FieldPulse

Trade-off	Stakeholder	Why this pairing
Async audit write (TCD trade-off 2)	Compliance Lead	Decides if 10-sec lag is acceptable
Modular monolith vs new service (TCD trade-off 1)	Architect	Decides architectural posture
ticket_ids denormalization (TMD trade-off)	Eng Director	Decides if "future query may be hard" is acceptable
Region/AZ active-passive vs active-active (TMD Section 2)	CFO + Architect	Cost + architecture together

Activity 3 — Draft the 1-Page Brief

Format: Triad • 40 min • Block 3

Purpose

Draft the brief. The 1-page constraint is hard.

Triad protocol

1. **Write "the decision" sentence** (5 min). One sentence. If it requires two, the trade-off isn't sharp enough.
2. **Write "why this matters to you"** (10 min). 1–2 sentences in their currency. Run through the predicted 5 questions to make sure this answers their #1.

3. **Write "the choice"** (10 min). 2–3 bullets each: what we're doing / not doing / cost.
4. **Write "what would change our mind"** (5 min). One concrete trigger.
5. **Write "what we need from you"** (5 min). Checkboxes; specific.
6. **Write the appendix linkbox** (5 min).

What "good" looks like

- **Whole brief on one page** — the page constraint is forcing
- **Plain language** in the headline; technical terms only in the appendix references
- **Cost in their currency** — dollars for CFO, customer experience for CS, audit risk for Compliance
- **Specific ask** at the end — not "thoughts welcome"

Worked example — Async audit write brief for Compliance

```
# Trade-off brief: Reconcile audit write timing
**For:** Pat Lee, Compliance Lead | **From:** Reconcile triad |
**Date:** 2026-04-29

## The decision
We are choosing async audit write (1-10s lag) over synchronous
(instant)
to keep dispatcher reconcile screens fast.

## Why this matters to you
This affects the audit-trail timing your SOC 2 process depends on.
Audit
events are still durable (Kafka topic + DLQ) – they just appear in the
audit store 1-10 seconds after the user action.

## The choice
– **What we're doing:** Publish audit events to a durable Kafka topic
at
  user-action time; consumer writes to audit store within 1-10 seconds.
– **What we're explicitly not doing:** Synchronous write to audit store
  on the user's hot path (would add 30-80ms; breaks our p95 SL0).
– **The cost we're accepting:** A regulator querying within 5 seconds
of
  an event sees stale state.

## What would change our mind
A regulator or customer contractually requires synchronous audit
visibility within < 1 second.

## What we need from you
□ Approval that the 1-10s lag is acceptable for our SOC 2 process
□ Confirmation of acceptable lag bound (we propose ≤ 10s p99)
□ Note of any contract requiring sync audit (we know of none)

## Appendix
– Technical detail: TCD Section 5 trade-off 2, TMD Section 4 sequence
  diagrams
– Latency budget: TCD Section 4
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Activity 4 — Cross-Review + AI Critique

Format: Triad-pair • 45 min + Wrap • Block 4

Purpose

Cross-review with another triad **playing the stakeholder role**. Use AI to predict objections.

Cross-review protocol (20 min)

1. **Pair up triads** — instructor assigns.
2. **Reviewer triad reads the brief in role** (10 min). They read as if they were the named stakeholder. They underline:
 - Sentences that lose them (jargon, irrelevant, unclear)
 - Sentences they'd push back on
 - The first question they'd ask
3. **Author triad listens to feedback** (10 min). Capture; do not defend. Same Week-3 review discipline.

AI critique (15 min)

Role: <stakeholder type – e.g., CFO, Compliance Lead, Sales VP>
Context: <paste the brief>
Task: Read this as if you were the named stakeholder.

- What's the first question you'd ask?
- What concern is unaddressed?
- What word or phrase loses you?

Constraints:

- Be specific to the brief, not generic
- Voice the stakeholder's perspective honestly

Format: Numbered list – Question / Concern / Word that loses you.

Triad action (10 min)

Adopt / defer / reject. Update Section 3.

Wrap (last 15 min)

Each triad shares:

- Their **decision sentence** read aloud (the test of clarity)
- The **stakeholder question** they're least sure how to answer
- One **word they cut** from the technical version

End-of-day checkpoint

Each triad ends Day 3 with:

- ✓ **One TCD/TMD trade-off** picked + stakeholder paired

- ✓ **5 predicted questions** ranked
- ✓ **One-page brief** in the SEP Section 3 template
- ✓ Cross-reviewed (in role) + AI-critiqued
- ✓ Provenance log entry
- ✓ SEP Section 3 drafted